

Support system: Vijay Sharma believes that Mirabai is a once-in-a-generation weightlifter.

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Mirabai was making three snatch repetitions of one of the weights she had lifted at the World Cup. "The medal isn't something that we are too worried about. We will be fighting for a medal in Paris. I don't know which colour it will be, though," he says.

It's a bold prediction from Sharma, who admits the competition in Paris will be a lot harder than it was last time in Tokyo. "At that time, the biggest hurdle for Mira wasn't the rest of the field but just her own fear after what had happened in Rio. The Chinese girl was very strong, but no one else was really competing with her. This time around, the Chinese girl (Hou Zhihui) is very strong, but there are also three very strong girls — from the USA (Jourdan Delacruz, personal best 200kg), Romania (Mihaela Cambei PB 200kg), and Thailand (either Surodchana Khambao or Thanyathon Sukcharoen — both of whom have PBs of 200kg). It will most likely be four weightlifters competing for two medals," he says.

He has little doubt Mirabai will come through. "Her technique is much better than what it used to be even three years ago, and her strength is about the same. All these other weightlifters also have a personal best of 200kg. They will probably have to lift their personal best once again in Paris. On the other hand, Mirabai can get to 200kg even on an average day," he says.

What also helps, he says, is her unrelenting motivation. "She is no doubt a once-in-a-generation weightlifter. She has the passion to achieve something. Mira already had an Olympic medal. She didn't need to



struggle so much just to get ready for the Olympics.

"But she is someone who is never satisfied with anything. Even though she has a record of 119kg in clean and jerk, which no one in India has done to date, she is still not satisfied. She has also won a World Championship gold and an Olympic medal, which no other Indian has.

Yet she is not satisfied. I think even if she wins another medal at the Olympics, she will still not be satisfied. She will keep pushing herself," he says.

These are bold predictions, but he says neither he nor Mirabai is under any pressure. "Compared to the Tokyo Olympics, there's almost no stress this time. All the stress got slapped out of us after what happened at the Asian Games last year. We were so confident in our preparation, and then we were hit with a disaster. This time we are training with complete sincerity and going to leave the rest to God," he says.

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